

respond calmly. Then, if it's appropriate, defend yourself. If her criticism is just, nod as she speaks. Tell her, "Thank you for showing me how you would prefer this to be done / how this should be done / how to add a column of numbers / whatever." If she persists, or is talking to you about something for the nth time, say, "This seems to be something that you want me to work on / I should work on. Are there any resources available to help me improve?" Whether you need to be on time, make the web page load faster, or something else, it's hard for a boss to fault an employee who wants to change. If she points you in a direction, follow through!

WHEN YOU'RE SWAMPED AND HE WANTS YOU TO DO MORE:

Be honest about what you can do. Most supervisors appreciate hearing when their people are overworked and stressed. If he likes up-front, honest people, say, "You know, I'd be happy to take that on, but realistically I won't be able to get to it until I finish with X, Y, and Z. Will that work for you?" He may take it to someone else, or he may give it to you, but either way he knows what he's looking at. If he's going to lay it on you no matter what you say, try, "I'll take

that on. Right now, I'm working on P, D, and Q. Where does this fall in priority relative to those?" With this, he knows where he stands and what you have on your plate, and he can determine when you get to it.

WHEN YOU KNOW YOU'VE MADE A BIG MISTAKE:

If you can't fix it in time, be the first to let her know. Swallow the butterflies and make your weak knees walk to her office (or write that email). Most of the time she's going to find out anyway, so you're only prolonging the agony and creating a ton of anxiety for yourself if you don't tell her. Your poise and honesty will also make an impression, even if she's upset and there are consequences. At the very least, she'll have a positive sense of your integrity for any future recommendations. At best? You might save your job.

WHEN YOU'RE INTERVIEWING FOR A DIFFERENT JOB:

In a few companies, this is considered tantamount to treason. If you work for one of them, keep it under the table but don't lie if you're asked directly. You might be asked to leave, but they won't be able to fault your integrity in a recommendation. But if you work for most companies (or, at least,